

Erdic Philosophy & Spiritualism

Erdic culture is built upon their own sense of time and secular spirituality.

Time

Erds do not believe in “now”. Whatever that is not yet fully gone (in the past) is considered “future”. This also applies to things started in the past which still have effect.

Erdic culture is heavily bound to the contradiction of past and future intertwining - making those two concepts complementary to each other.

The Garden of Existence

Erdic spirituality revolves around the concept that is named The Garden, sometimes also The Garden of Existence or names bringing life or universe to the context.

The Garden is portrayed as three platforms of increasing width the higher they get - each level bringing different meaning to the circle of life.

While the concept itself is very abstract, it is used to guide everyday life of erdic society because “what is outside, is also inside”. Therefore it is not uncommon to refer to areas in life as “gardens”, with places taking precedence (so “garden” is house, not family, even though the house encompasses family to great extent).

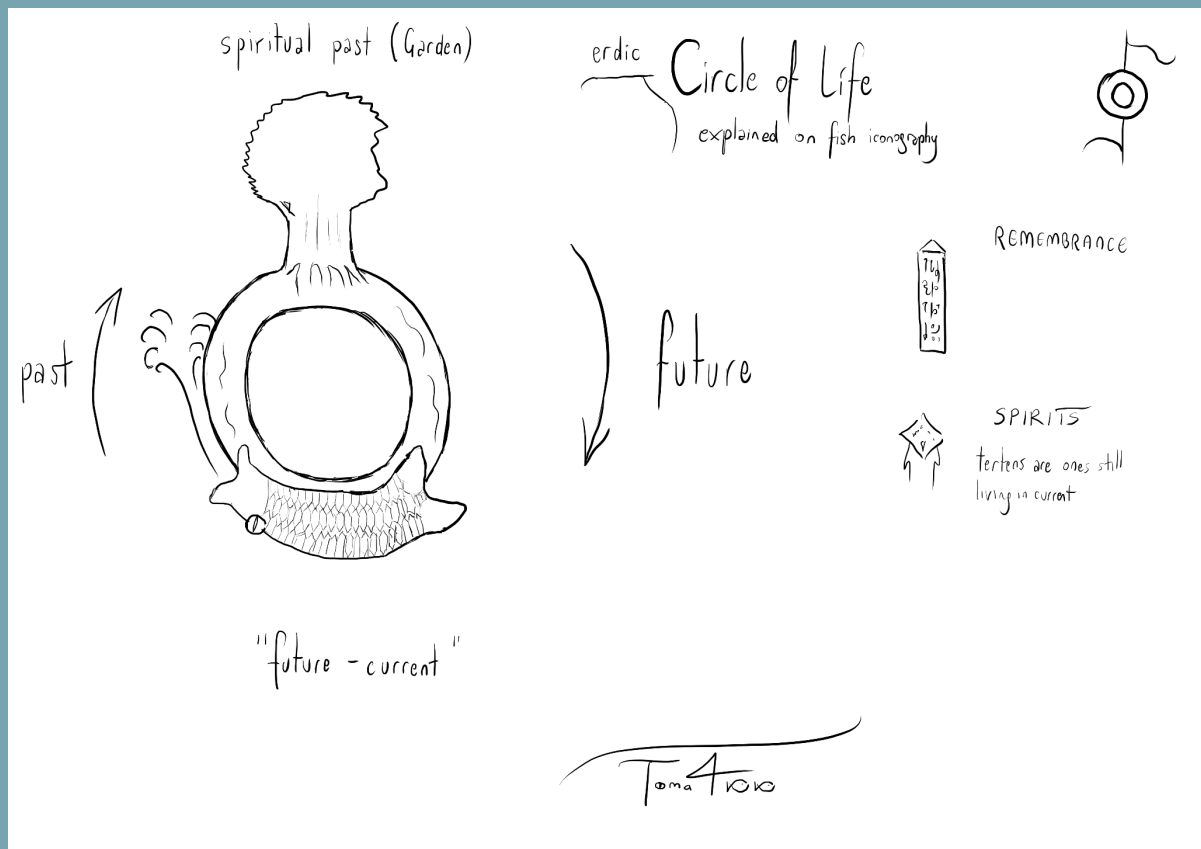
The Circle of Life

Waters flow from Palace, to the lakes of Garden, and down they go to the earth – filling the universe with life.

Water of the Garden, or in more theistic interpretation, Water spilled by the Gardener – is universally seen as the origin of all life. It is loosely bound to the oceans and seas around, but understood more as a symbolic than myth materialised – following the secular character of erdic vision.

The water flowing down from The Garden brings life into the universe, creating what is considered “the future”. But the time is circular, and so there’s also “the past” – everything that descended into the universe, needs to ascend back to The Garden, giving back life it was once given.

Water sometimes is also used interchangeably with breath, as a more direct representation of the concept. This can be seen in fish symbol, where fish spits the water out towards the past (synonymous to the saying “each breath belongs to the past”):



Therefore “the past” is not passive, it is active and spiritually seen as a journey forwards, not backwards. We all wander toward the past, from our future given.

Taking Care of The Garden

Despite “the past” being the ultimate destination of all beings, erdic culture is about fostering care about things that are “the future” (still existing).

The existence of the Palace (or Gardener) shows the ultimate sense of this structure – and it is *taking care of the garden*, providing “the future” to beings around you, so they can follow their own journey. Thus, maintenance is one of the base principles under which erdic society operates on – and it is extrapolated in consequential order, with each level containing the previous “Garden”:

- ★ Garden is Sphere (outside of world)
- ★ Garden is World (outside of city)
- ★ Garden is City (outside of home)

★ Garden is Home (outside of being)

★ Garden is Being (outside of life waters)

The circularity of this system makes it showcase the law of mimicry – every law existing on one scope, should be applicable to another.

Taking care means that you allow something to ascend back to The Garden – therefore, erds rule out evil by simply abandoning it, as over time, nature will erase it by itself. There's a strong belief that in the sacred wheel of time, everything evil eventually will cease to exist.

This is why in Roda, the Baedoor District is not financed by the city ruler, as it reminds natives of the occupation time. Over the years, the district indeed turned into ruin and is now on the edge of becoming abandoned if not for the few residents still living there.

Tradition and Progress

The circular character of future ascending into the past makes erdic fairly traditional society, however they do not consider progress as something detrimental to the past – as long as progress maintains it, it is part of the whole.

Therefore erdic society tends to embrace progress in limited ways, filtering out what can disturb the order of The Garden, but inviting anything that does not. The definition of tradition and progress are also not necessarily existing, as they blur with each other.

***Evil**

"The good wins through the patience" – Len Mari

The Care of the Garden is considered as the ultimate good that the community should strive towards – the evil, in this case, is understood as everything that disrupts said order.

The principle of care explains a lot of how evil should be treated – the general response to it should be ignoring, if the evil is not actively trying to bring disorder to our smaller garden.

However, in situations when that happens (or when there's a possibility of that), yet another principle takes place – it is the rule of responsibility.

The Garden is not an isolated place, and neither are our “lower gardens”. Therefore, ...

***Theism**

***Death**

When erd dies, their body is temporarily stored in a coffin. The procession then goes to the nearest temple's garden, with a flutist playing on their flute when the family passes the streets. Everyone is welcome to escort the dead to their garden home, the event itself is not private.

When the coffin reaches the garden, temple workers prepare the area in it for the body of the dead. They then take the body out of the coffin and lie in the desired place, with guests and family sharing seeds and flowers they would like to grow nearby. They are planted with great care.

With a few songs following this event, the ceremony ends. The family (or house coinhabitants) then follow the priest to the temple to write the sheet which will then be hung in the Great Room in the temple, and the house shared by the dead.

*Care of the Dead







Erds note their dead on paper (or material) sheets, hanged in their houses and sanctuaries/temples, with the latter maintaining the funerals in the (actual) garden built around the building.



The Temple/Home sanctuary is a symbolic chain between public and private. That's why Temple only covers name and address, while Home covers history, memory of the dead.

It's also the reason why the sanctuary is such a sacred aspect, aside from "house" (building) being one of the gardens of life.

***Spirits**

[The understanding of spirits, how they relate to Circle of Life order, what they are and what is relation of erds towards them]

***Orders and Their Understanding In Society**

Home

Home is a concept that erds do treat as somewhat interchangeable to family – it does encompass their social life within the closest circle, but is also an indicator of both "past" and "future-present" to which home is both a sanctuary.

The past is reflected in continuous ownership, and the remembrance area where the memory of the dead is kept.

The future-present is reflected on the other hand, in continuous living in the place, and the relationships between dwellers is what matters.

This dynamic creates two needs: the economic one (home dwellers work towards betterness of home, to not lose it – however not really to migrate, which is somewhat keeping most erds within their eternal status quo) and ethical one (dwellers try to keep relationships healthy, as it not only reflects the health of home and helps the economic factor succeed, but also being exiled from home is treated as a soft curse).

The fact that erds do not read these through the lens of family per se has consequences: if someone invites friend or lover to live with them, this move can be considered ultimately intimate, akin to marriage in family-based societies (this also creates a difficult situation for the invited, as it means symbolically cutting ties with currently-lived home). Similarly, the fact of being part of a family doesn't protect anyone from being exiled. This often creates

situations where young people can be exiled for various reasons – loving someone they shouldn't, or nonconforming – and either search for shelter or find it in a different home, symbolically changing their identity.

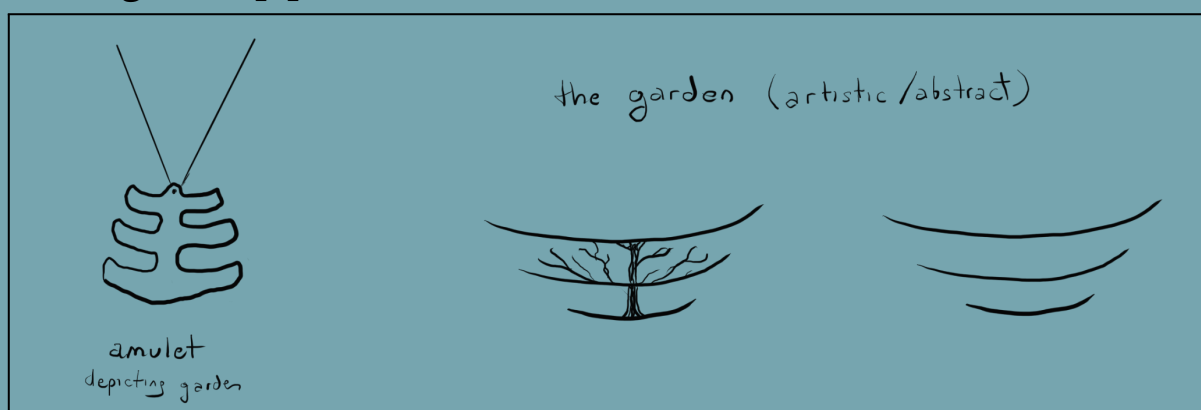
House guild system is an extension of this understanding of “home”, because it is seen as a “home for the idea, and like-minded”. The word that is less emotionally charged indicates the difference, but the symbolic link persists.

This also explains how Houses differ from guilds and organisations, being both very informal, yet having formal structures or being recognised by higher institutions.

*Symbolism

Erdic concepts are often depicted in symbolic – sometimes very abstract – ways. One of the more common visual tropes is **The Garden** – depicted as three slightly rounded lines, portraying each level of it.

In less abstract art, erds tend to use tree branches as a common motif, adding more meaning where each level “cares” about each other – the lowest by giving birth to the tree, the middle tree by holding the top palace.



Tree and branches motif is fairly common in many places – be it tapestries, murals or decorative wares.

It is also a popular way for some sects to mark the membership – more theistic sects tend to create their own face tattoos that depict

branches, as a way to publicly manifest their belief.

Some sects tend to create their own dedicated motif that is shared between all members, however a lot of individuals or less dedicated sects do not hold to specific design – it is by no means coherent.

Another frequent motif is the use of **flowers**, specifically in ways mixing simple abstraction with realism, as seen in art nouveau and japanese art. It's worth noting however that erds emphasize simplicity and balance, so their art should try to use "less is more" motto and rather than overstimulating with details, lead the viewer with few rich depictions of focus, leaving the rest of the image as rather minimal pure colour/texture.

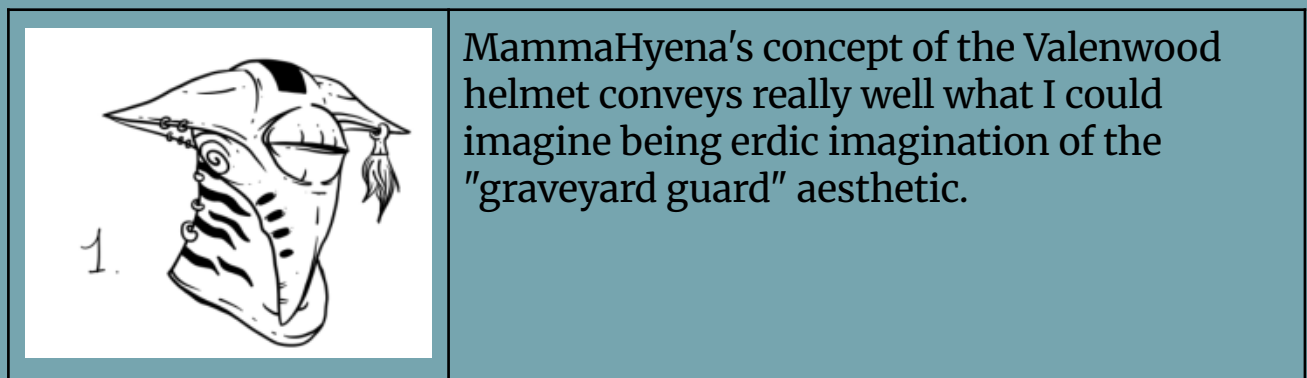
Girls sometimes paint flowers on their cheeks or around their eyes as a form of cheerful makeup.





Another symbol used by erdic philosophy and religion is **circle of life** - which is pretty much telling the truth of descension and ascension - the water of life descends from the future to the universe, and every being is slowly ascending towards death, giving back the life it was given.

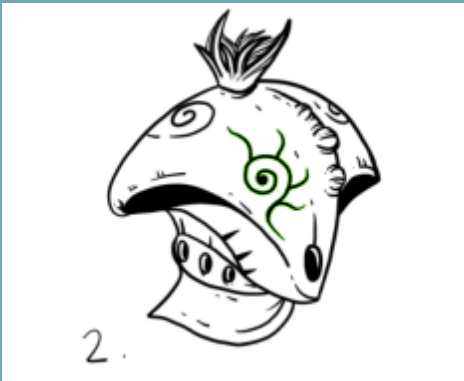
The symbol also includes a smaller circle that showcases the principle of mimicry - what is the law of the universe outside, is the law of the universe inside.



MammaHyena's concept of the Valenwood helmet conveys really well what I could imagine being erdic imagination of the "graveyard guard" aesthetic.

Eye is a symbol of time - the time understood how erds see it, as the past and the future. Just like life flows into us and as we are in the future until our eyes close, the **opened eye** represents the future. It is a symbol of knowledge that is and can be learned. It also represents the all-seeing, the eternal nature of gardener that erdic culture considers as sacred obligation of everyone.

Closed eye represents the past – everything that is no longer in the future and that ascended the Garden. Just like the gardener takes care of the Garden, erds do the same to the dead – with Temple guards' armours containing a closed eye as an inverse symbolism of protecting sacred graveyards in Roda, Disane and Kaer's cities.



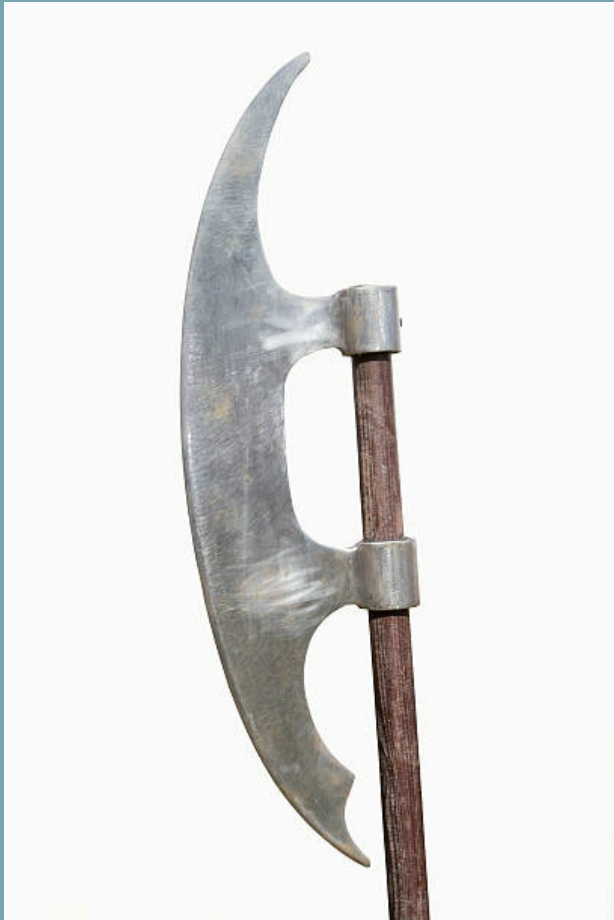
Another MammaHyena's concept had an amazing spiral motif, with sort of "branches" leading out of it. It really sparked my imagination and brought the idea of some cultural pollination between ormaths, saphtri and erds over centuries.

Spiral is a bit of an old symbol that southern races (ormaths, saphtris and erds) use for depicting the spiritual world. It originates from ormaths, hence it has less visual logic than other erdic symbols and is also fairly rare nowadays within this culture.

On a bit more niche symbolism, the **halberd** is a less common symbol that encompasses ideas of safety, stability and erdic integrity. It is sometimes also used to emphasize tradition and the longevity of erdic culture and roots.

Erdic halberd is a bit circular and can take a bit more unusual shape, so don't treat below references as final depiction (the chinese one is the most interesting, however could probably be integrated with more typical look)





Colour is an important part of erdic identity, being used from architecture, clothing, through tapestries and tableware, to writing. Erds embrace the richness of colours, however they often pick some specific ones. The most commonly used are **intense red**, **cream white/yellow**, **cream red**, **purple** and **dark/regular green**, with **darker orange** and **yellow** being also seen from time to time.

Blue is rare and is never dominant, pure white and black is absent pretty much.

***Music**

The dominant instruments used by erds are rather soft and playful – they range from lyres, through guitars, to bells (bigger and smaller) and triangles. They bring mesmerising, vibrative character to places where they are played.

Some modern instrumentarium that got imported during Empire occupation also found its place in erdic homes and inns, albeit is still seen as a curiosity.

Wind instruments (wind chimes, flutes) are considered philosophically and featured heavily in such contexts. They signify "breath" and so the passing of the future towards the past. The funeral ceremony is characterised by the procession that is guided by flutist – guiding the dead towards the temple garden. The ethereal sound dances on the streets, piercing the loudness of everyday life, clearing the way before the funeral crowd.